tough time’. It was a day of emotional reactions. An eighty-four-year-old retired government servant passionately spoke about Ratan and the Parsi community. He questioned why Mistry and Wadia were not present at the meeting. He also said that Mistry should ‘apologize to Mr Tata’. Expressions of loyalty towards the Tatas and particularly Ratan abounded. One shareholder said, ‘The battle should have been kept to the boardroom and not brought into public.’ Another said vehemently, ‘Those who are not with the Tatas, are not with the nation.’

A majority of 90.8 per cent of the total valid votes cast were in favour of removing Wadia as independent director. At the end of the EGM, on being asked by reporters if he was content with the way the retail investors had backed him, Ratan answered in the affirmative.

The following day saw the Tata Motors EGM. Before it began, Wadia once again wrote to the company’s shareholders. He alleged that the ‘recent meetings’ of other Tata companies were conducted improperly. They had ‘been inappropriately and shamefully stage managed by the requisitionist (Tata Sons) controlling the entry into the hall as also in the selection and choice of speakers as never before seen in Indian Corporate history’, he said.

Finally, Wadia said: ‘It is for you the shareholders of Tata Motors who own 70 per cent of the shares of your company to decide whether you want to be the holder of Tata Sons shares with minimum return, zero liquidity and no exit.’

Ratan attended the EGM that went on for over four hours. About 1,517 shareholders or 71.20 per cent voted to remove Wadia. But he had his supporters too. Some questioned the board and Ratan for removing him.

Yet again, a day before the Tata Chemicals EGM on 23 December, Wadia wrote to the company’s shareholders with a similar agenda. Ratan attended this as well. At the EGM, the shareholders voted by a majority of 76 per cent to remove Wadia as the director. Many of them were overwhelmed by Ratan’s presence. Four shareholders hoped that the government would confer the Bharat Ratna on Ratan. One of them, Shailesh Mahadevia, characterized him as a ‘disciple of God on earth’ and another, Mahesh Jain, termed him a ‘pillar of our society’.

Mukundan recalls that during the meeting, there was a demand from the shareholders for Ratan to speak. Ratan obliged. He stated that ‘truth will prevail’ and thanked the shareholders for their ‘overwhelming and